

Foucault and Power

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Introduction

Foucault (2012) introduces Panopticism through an overview of a plague stricken town in which people are quarantined through the use of extreme measures of discipline. It demonstrates a concentration of state's forceful power that is used to bring order and utopia of a perfectly governed city. As Foucault explains, this is one type of power, the one most commonly understood, where force is used to assert dominance over other people. The other kind, as he explains in relation to Panopticons described by Bentham (1995), is a form of a more subtle power. One that he says "automatizes and disindividualizes power".

The primary idea is that power doesn't have to be forceful rather it can be subtle and formed through an arrangement of concentration and distribution of people, systems and gazes; producing a mechanical relationship amongst people in which they are caught. As Foucault describes, "a real subjection is born mechanically from a fictitious relation and so it is not necessary to use force to constraint the convict to good behavior."

The idea of visible but unverifiable power that Foucault describes through the use of Panopticons is a powerful one. It effectively challenges the organization of our society, purporting that everything is a Panopticon: our schools, our hospitals, our offices and so forth. Bentham's primary idea of a Panopticon is that a single guard tower is present in the middle of a circular prison, each with individual cells that can be seen through the guard tower. However, the guard tower itself has a glass pane such that although the prisoners know that they are visible from the guard tower, they cannot verify if someone is watching them. Therefore, they assume that they are being watched all the time, allowing the guards to take days off without affecting the status quo of the prison. Foucault extends this idea to the modern society of putting people under observation and how supposedly improvised institutions as prisons (instead of public executions which said to be inhumane) are extreme torture cells. Not only are modern prisons modelled after the Panopticon, but so is the entire society as power is diffused rather than concentrated, embodied and enacted rather than possessed, discursive rather than purely coercive, and constitutes agents rather

than being deployed by them (Gaventa, 2003). We are being watched all the time - by our neighbors, by our co-workers, by the state, by our teachers, by our doctors, by our classmates and so forth. Not only are we being watched, but we also watch each of these actors. This constant state of being under surveillance as well as being the one who surveils is another feature of this Panoptic power that forms a social structure keeping each actor in check. According to him, it doesn't matter what the motives of each actor are, the Panopticon is a marvellous machine which, whatever use one may wish to put it to, produces power that grasps everyone. He might concur, having me to write this paper, is a form of Panoptic power, that has been forced upon me to ensure that I read about Foucault. I haven't been put down by a gun to write this, nevertheless it's expected of me to write good papers and I hopefully have done so.

While these ideas of power are not new, they are highly visible in the world around us today from surveillance based digital Panopticons (Koskella, 2003) to the divisive politics of the contemporary United States (Knauf, 2018). Most recently, the currently developing COVID-19 outbreak (Wu, Leung, & Leung) has prompted the People's Republic of China to quarantine some 700M people, or 10% of humanity, in ways similar to those described by Foucault as measures undertaken during the plague (Zhong & Mozur, 2020). Not only has Chinese military come to streets and police forces deployed to enforce mandatory quarantines (Zhong & Mozur, 2020), the traditional power by force, President Xi has declared "a people's war" against the virus and has effectively encouraged common people to partake in policing of their neighbors, to report those that are suspected to be sick, and to ensure that people are not seen on the streets (Feng, 2020). This is exactly what Foucault describes as the Panoptic power where the Chinese state has: (a) involved the general public to be surveillers (while being surveilled themselves) (b) has an omnipresent visible but not verifiable power through the well-identified Great Firewall of China such that ALL internet traffic is monitored (Leibold, 2020). There are enforced temperature checks using remote drones (Hermesauto, 2020), which might or might not work, but demonstrate a visible power of the state that makes people compelled to follow the social order imposed by the government. In places without lockdown, temperature checks are needed to allow use of public transport (Xu, 2020) even though

such temperature checks are not the sole predictors of those infected (Rothe et al, 2020). Such measures are in direct corollary to Foucault's idea of building a fictitious relationship which entraps people in a mechanical system that enforces order and discipline.

To no surprise, as Foucault recalls, such power DOES WORK - WHO and the international community has appraised chinese efforts of containing the virus (Joseph & Thielking, 2020) with blatant disregard to the panoptic measures employed.

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